

Chicken Wild Rice Soup

Whole bird · wild rice-forward · thick, spoon-coating, Upper Midwest style

YIELD	TIME	POT	STOCK
~6 L · 10–12	1.5 / 3.5 hr	10 qt+ poach · 8 qt+ soup	2500 g, no reduction

INGREDIENTS

stock = body + fat · Better Than Bouillon = chicken flavor

BIRD & STOCK

Whole chicken 4.5–5 lb, giblets out	2.0–2.3 kg
Cold water to submerge	6000 g

WILD RICE

Wild rice true, not a blend	325 g
Water	1800 g
Salt like pasta water	to taste

SOUP BASE

Unsalted butter up to half as skimmed chicken fat	150 g
Yellow onion diced	360 g
Carrots diced	270 g
Celery diced	270 g
Cremini sliced	400 g
Garlic minced	22 g
All-purpose flour	110 g
Dry sherry	55 g
Homemade stock strained	2500 g
Better Than Bouillon Roasted Chicken	30 g
Dried thyme	2 g
Bay leaves	2

FINISH

Pulled chicken all of it	~650–900 g
Cooked wild rice all of it	~1.1 kg
Heavy cream	430 g
Kosher salt start; finish to taste	10 g
Black pepper fresh ground	4 g
Lemon juice the acid	18 g
Parsley chopped	15 g

KEY TARGETS

the cues that decide the pot

Poach water	Bare simmer, 180–195°F — surface shivers, a stray bubble. A boil clouds the stock and tightens the meat.
Pull the bird	Thickest thigh 175–180°F , leg wiggles loose — about 50–70 min.
Wild rice	Most kernels split open. Lake/hand-parched ~20–30 min; glossy black paddy ~45–60 min.
Sweat & roux	Butter foaming, never browning; vegetables soft with no color. Roux 2–3 min — smells toasty, stays blond.
Thickness	Coats the back of a spoon before the rice goes in — the rice thickens it further.
Cream in	Last, heated through below a boil.

Taste only after the chicken and rice are in. About 2 kg of unseasoned meat and rice goes in at the end and soaks up salt — a soup that tastes right before them tastes flat after. Expect to go past the 10 g of salt; add it in small hits.

Execution

METHOD

stock → rice (during the carcass simmer) → soup

STOCK — 10 QT POT

- 1 **Poach:** 2.0–2.3 kg chicken + 6000 g cold water. Bring up to a **bare simmer (180–195°F)**; skim foam for the first 15 min. Poach until the thigh reads **175–180°F**, about 50–70 min.
- 2 **Pull:** lift the bird out; the pot stays at a bare simmer. Cool 15 min, strip all meat, discard skin, shred bite-size. **Meat → set aside for step 11.** Bones + cartilage back into the pot.
- 3 **Carcass:** lid on, bare simmer **60–90 min.** Start the rice and chop the vegetables now.

RICE — DURING THE CARCASS SIMMER

- 4 **Rice:** rinse **325 g wild rice**; simmer covered in **1800 g water**, salted like pasta water, until most kernels split. Drain. **Rice → set aside for step 11.**

SOUP — CLEAN 8 QT POT

- 5 **Strain:** strain the stock; skim the fat off the top and save it. Weigh out **2500 g stock** for the soup; save the rest (~3 kg). Stir **30 g Better Than Bouillon** into a ladle of the hot stock until dissolved.
- 6 **Sweat:** melt **150 g butter** (up to 75 g of it can be the skimmed chicken fat) until foaming. Add **360 g onion, 270 g carrots, 270 g celery**; cook until soft with no color, ~10 min.
- 7 **Mushrooms:** add **400 g cremini**; cook until their liquid is gone and the edges brown, ~10 min. Add **22 g garlic**, 1 min.
- 8 **Roux:** sprinkle **110 g flour** over the vegetables; stir **2–3 min** until it smells toasty. Stays blond.
- 9 **Liquid:** **55 g sherry** in, scrape the bottom. Whisk in the **2500 g stock** a ladle at a time (a dump makes lumps), then the dissolved **Better Than Bouillon, 2 g thyme, 2 bay leaves, 5 g salt**. Bring to a simmer.
- 10 **Simmer:** uncovered **20–30 min**, scraping the bottom as you stir (the roux settles and scorches), until the raw-flour taste is gone and it coats a spoon.
- 11 **Finish:** bay leaves out. Stir in **all the chicken, all the rice, 430 g cream**; heat through below a boil. **Now taste** — the other **5 g salt** (and more if needed) in small hits, **4 g pepper**, then **18 g lemon juice** off the heat. Top with **15 g parsley**.

TROUBLESHOOTING

three dials: Better Than Bouillon · salt · lemon

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Weak on chicken	Poach stock is light by nature	More Better Than Bouillon, a little at a time — before more salt (it's salty)
Flat overall	Chicken + rice absorbed the salt	Salt in small hits, stir, re-taste
Heavy, dull	Cream + roux with no lift	More lemon, a little at a time, off the heat
Too thin	Short simmer / rice not in yet	Simmer longer; it sets up further as it sits
Scorched bottom	Roux settled, not scraped	Move to a clean pot without scraping the burnt layer
Leftovers set solid	Wild rice keeps absorbing in the fridge	Thin with the saved stock when reheating